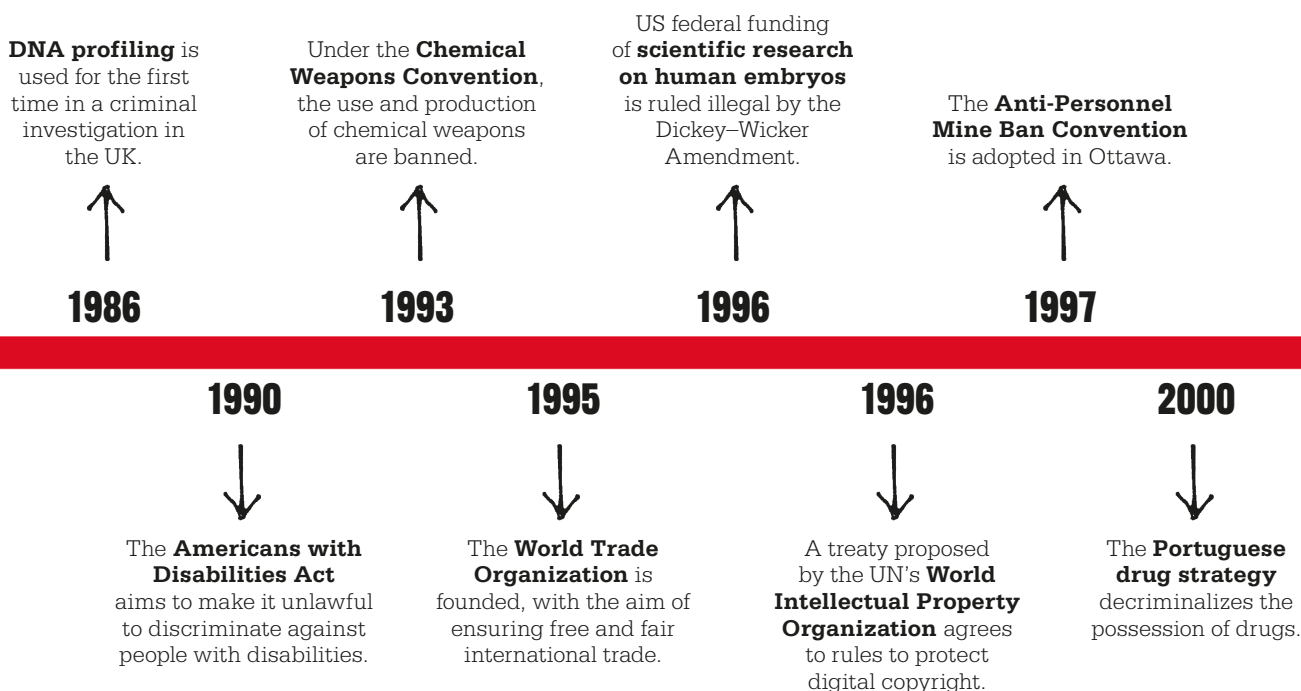




By the closing decades of the 20th century, the threat of new world wars had retreated, thanks to international cooperation and the work of the UN and its agencies. But these organizations could not stop the relentless loss of life in regional conflicts, from Kosovo and Sudan to Afghanistan and Syria. The effects of chemical weapons and the deadly legacy of landmines led to international Conventions imposing bans on both: the 1993 Chemical Weapons Convention and the Anti-Personnel Mine Ban Convention in 1997.

The world was rapidly becoming more interconnected. The growth in international trade and the burgeoning power of multinational corporations led to the founding of the World Trade Organization in

1995, its aim being to create a global framework for free trade. Yet it was not just the economic landscape that was changing; technological advances on a scale never seen before were ushering in a new era, as well as new legal challenges. In 1996, the World Intellectual Property Organization—an agency of the UN dedicated to defending trademarks, patents, and copyrights—turned its attention to the issues presented by a digital revolution. The need for regulation to safeguard intellectual property rights and ensure the security of data is evident, but as fast as technological solutions are introduced, determined hackers find ways of overcoming them. The law has struggled to keep pace.

Public access to digital data has also highlighted problems regarding privacy and individuals' ownership

of information about themselves. In 2014, the European Court of Justice ruled that the “right to be forgotten” trumps that of freedom of speech—but even this has been challenged.

Human rights

Public attitudes toward human rights and discrimination shifted fundamentally in some parts of the world. Campaigners brought pressure to bear on governments to enact laws protecting the rights of people with disabilities and recognizing the right of same-sex couples to marry. The US led the way with the former in 1990, the Netherlands with the latter in 2000, and other countries followed suit. In Iceland, equal pay certification obliges employers to undergo a regular audit to show that they offer equal pay for work of equal value.